Guitar Exercises — Section XI, Level 83

Melody Harmonization, Chord Substitution, Reharmonization, and Fixed-Top-Line Control

Level 83 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. Level 105 remains the hard stop.

Core hierarchy

1. Melody 2. Bass destination 3. Guide tones 4. Chord body 5. Color/extension

The same melody note can be a root, 3rd, 5th, 7th, or controlled extension. Reharmonization succeeds only when the new chord also improves or intentionally changes bass direction, voice leading, function, or color.

Module	Exercise	Events
A	Single melody-note harmonization	96
B	Diatonic harmonization of short melodies	128
C	Common-tone chord substitutions	112
D	Secondary-dominant and diminished substitutions	112
E	Bass reharmonization beneath a fixed top line	128
F	Guide-tone and inner-voice preservation	112
G	Harmonization density and reduction	96
H	Four eight-bar reharmonization studies	160
I	Twenty-four-bar melody-first capstone	192
J	Recovery and choice audit	64
	TOTAL	1200

Rule: sing the melody before forming any voicing. If the melody disappears, reduce immediately to bass + melody.

Reference — One Top Note, Several Harmonic Meanings

Cycle each top note through all candidate chords. Pass 1: melody alone. Pass 2: root + melody. Pass 3: shell + melody. Pass 4: complete voicing. Name the melody's role before each chord.

Top note	Candidate harmonies
C	Cmaj7 | Am7 | Fmaj7 | Dm7 | Abmaj7
D	Dm7 | G7 | Bm7b5 | Bbmaj7 | D7
E	Cmaj7 | Am7 | Em7 | A7 | Fmaj7
F	Dm7 | Fmaj7 | G7 | Bm7b5 | Dbmaj7
G	Cmaj7 | Em7 | G7 | Am7 | Ebmaj7
A	Dm7 | Fmaj7 | Am7 | D7 | A7
B	Cmaj7 | Em7 | G7 | B7 | Gmaj7

Module A/B — Fixed Top Note C

Hold or repeat **C** while changing the harmony beneath it. Do not move the melody merely because a new chord is easier to grip.

Candidate	Practice sequence	Decision question
Cmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Am7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Fmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Dm7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Abmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?

Choice audit

Which chord creates the smoothest bass? Which creates the strongest cadence? Which changes the key center? Which candidate would you reject, and why?

Module A/B — Fixed Top Note D

Hold or repeat **D** while changing the harmony beneath it. Do not move the melody merely because a new chord is easier to grip.

Candidate	Practice sequence	Decision question
Dm7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
G7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Bm7b5	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Bbmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
D7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?

Choice audit

Which chord creates the smoothest bass? Which creates the strongest cadence? Which changes the key center? Which candidate would you reject, and why?

Module A/B — Fixed Top Note E

Hold or repeat **E** while changing the harmony beneath it. Do not move the melody merely because a new chord is easier to grip.

Candidate	Practice sequence	Decision question
Cmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Am7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Em7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
A7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Fmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?

Choice audit

Which chord creates the smoothest bass? Which creates the strongest cadence? Which changes the key center? Which candidate would you reject, and why?

Module A/B — Fixed Top Note F

Hold or repeat **F** while changing the harmony beneath it. Do not move the melody merely because a new chord is easier to grip.

Candidate	Practice sequence	Decision question
Dm7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Fmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
G7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Bm7b5	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Dbmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?

Choice audit

Which chord creates the smoothest bass? Which creates the strongest cadence? Which changes the key center? Which candidate would you reject, and why?

Module A/B — Fixed Top Note G

Hold or repeat **G** while changing the harmony beneath it. Do not move the melody merely because a new chord is easier to grip.

Candidate	Practice sequence	Decision question
Cmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Em7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
G7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Am7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Ebmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?

Choice audit

Which chord creates the smoothest bass? Which creates the strongest cadence? Which changes the key center? Which candidate would you reject, and why?

Module A/B — Fixed Top Note A

Hold or repeat **A** while changing the harmony beneath it. Do not move the melody merely because a new chord is easier to grip.

Candidate	Practice sequence	Decision question
Dm7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Fmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Am7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
D7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
A7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?

Choice audit

Which chord creates the smoothest bass? Which creates the strongest cadence? Which changes the key center? Which candidate would you reject, and why?

Module A/B — Fixed Top Note B

Hold or repeat **B** while changing the harmony beneath it. Do not move the melody merely because a new chord is easier to grip.

Candidate	Practice sequence	Decision question
Cmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Em7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
G7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
B7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?
Gmaj7	melody → root+melody → shell+melody → full voicing	Stable chord tone, useful color, or tension needing resolution?

Choice audit

Which chord creates the smoothest bass? Which creates the strongest cadence? Which changes the key center? Which candidate would you reject, and why?

Module C — Common-Tone Chord Substitution

Fixed melody	Harmony	Changing role
E	Cmaj7 → Am7 → Fmaj7	3 → 5 → 7
G	Cmaj7 → Em7 → G7	5 → b3 → root
C	Am7 → Fmaj7 → Cmaj7	b3 → 5 → root
F	Dm7 → G7 → Fmaj7	b3 → b7 → root
B	Cmaj7 → Em7 → Gmaj7	7 → 5 → 3
A	Dm7 → Fmaj7 → Am7	5 → 3 → root

Keep the top note fixed. Move bass and inner voices by the smallest available intervals. Then create one additional substitute for each row.

Module D — Secondary Dominants and Passing Diminished Chords

Top	Progression	Function
C#	Cmaj7 → A7 → Dm7	C# is 3 of A7; resolve into Dm7
F#	Cmaj7 → D7 → G7	F# is 3 of D7; resolve toward G
D#	Gmaj7 → B7 → Em7	D# is 3 of B7; resolve to E/G
E	Cmaj7 → C#dim7 → Dm7	common/connector tone
G	G7 → G#dim7 → Am7	passing diminished function
A	Fmaj7 → F#dim7 → G7	chromatic bass connector

The chromatic chord must have a destination. Remove it first; verify the source-to-destination progression still works; then reinsert it as brief motion.

Module E — Bass Reharmonization Beneath a Fixed Melody

Fixed melody: **E E E E | G G G G**. Build four different bass paths, then harmonize every bass note without moving the written top line.

Version	Bass path	Task
1	C-B-A-G	Diatonic descent
2	C-E-F-G	Arpeggiated/functional rise
3	C-C#-D-G	Chromatic approach into predominant
4	C-Bb-A-G	Borrowed/chromatic descent

Reduction test: play bass + melody only. If the intended direction disappears, the reharmonization is relying too heavily on inner voices.

Module F — Preserve Guide-Tone Motion

Harmony	Top line	Guide line	Bass
Cmaj7-Am7-Dm7-G7	Top E-E-F-B	Inner B-C-C-B	Bass C-A-D-G
Cmaj7-A7-Dm7-G7	Top E-C#-F-B	Inner B-G-C-F	Bass C-A-D-G
Gmaj7-B7-Em7-A7	Top B-D#-G-C#	Inner F#-A-D-G	Bass G-B-E-A
Am7-Dm7-E7-AmMaj7	Top C-F-G#-G#	Inner G-C-D-E	Bass A-D-E-A

Sing top and guide lines separately, then together. Add bass only after both upper voices are secure.

Module G — Harmonization Density and Reduction

Pass	Texture
1	Melody only
2	Bass + melody
3	Bass + one guide tone + melody
4	Full four-note chord melody
5	Remove one inner voice while preserving function
6	Add one extension only if melody and bass remain dominant

Use the same eight-bar melody for every pass. Tempo, phrasing, and melody dynamics may not change simply because the harmony becomes denser.

Module H — Study 1 — Diatonic

Melody: E F G E | D E F D

Baseline harmony: Cmaj7 | Dm7 | Em7 | Cmaj7

Pass	Assignment
1	Melody alone
2	Baseline bass + melody
3	Baseline full voicings
4	Create a new bass path; melody unchanged
5	Create a new full harmonization; at least two roots differ
6	Create one conservative and one adventurous reharmonization

Verify every melody/chord relationship, bass direction, guide-tone motion, cadence strength, register, and hand economy.

Module H — Study 2 — Relative substitutes

Melody: C C B A | G E F G

Baseline harmony: Am7 | Fmaj7 | G7 | Cmaj7

Pass	Assignment
1	Melody alone
2	Baseline bass + melody
3	Baseline full voicings
4	Create a new bass path; melody unchanged
5	Create a new full harmonization; at least two roots differ
6	Create one conservative and one adventurous reharmonization

Verify every melody/chord relationship, bass direction, guide-tone motion, cadence strength, register, and hand economy.

Module H — Study 3 — Secondary dominant

Melody: E E F# G | F# E D C#

Baseline harmony: Cmaj7 | A7 | D7 | A7

Pass	Assignment
1	Melody alone
2	Baseline bass + melody
3	Baseline full voicings
4	Create a new bass path; melody unchanged
5	Create a new full harmonization; at least two roots differ
6	Create one conservative and one adventurous reharmonization

Verify every melody/chord relationship, bass direction, guide-tone motion, cadence strength, register, and hand economy.

Module H — Study 4 — Chromatic color

Melody: G Ab G E | F F# G E

Baseline harmony: Cmaj7 | Abmaj7 | G7 | Cmaj7

Pass	Assignment
1	Melody alone
2	Baseline bass + melody
3	Baseline full voicings
4	Create a new bass path; melody unchanged
5	Create a new full harmonization; at least two roots differ
6	Create one conservative and one adventurous reharmonization

Verify every melody/chord relationship, bass direction, guide-tone motion, cadence strength, register, and hand economy.

Module I — Twenty-Four-Bar Melody-First Capstone

Bars 1-8: diatonic baseline. Bars 9-16: introduce secondary dominants and one passing diminished chord. Bars 17-24: reharmonize at least four measures while keeping the written melody unchanged.

Bar	Chord	Top
1	Cmaj7	E
2	Am7	E
3	Dm7	F
4	G7	B
5	Cmaj7	G
6	A7	C#
7	Dm7	F
8	G7	B
9	Em7	G
10	A7	C#
11	Dm7	F
12	G7	B
13	Cmaj7	E
14	C#dim7	E
15	Dm7	F
16	G7	B
17	Am7	C
18	D7	F#
19	Gmaj7	B
20	B7	D#
21	Em7	G
22	A7	C#
23	Dm7	F
24	G7	G

Module J — Recovery, Mastery, and Roadmap

Recovery hierarchy: preserve melody and pulse → state destination bass → reduce to bass+melody → restore guide tones → restore full voicing → add substitutions last.

Category	0	1	2
Melody clarity	lost	functional	dominant/clear
Bass logic	unclear	functional	directed
Chord quality	wrong	mostly clear	clear
Guide-tone motion	lost	functional	smooth
Substitution function	random	plausible	purposeful
Voicing cleanliness	noisy	usable	clean
Form/pulse	lost	recovers	stable
Recovery	restart	simplifies	seamless

Pass: 14/16 or better on two separate days, with no zero in melody clarity, bass logic, form/pulse, or recovery.

Fixed roadmap: Level 84 completes Section XI. Levels 85-90 Groove & Stylistic Rhythm. Levels 91-94 Advanced Expression & Articulation. Levels 95-99 Repertoire Integration. Levels 100-104 Composition & Improvisational Composition. Level 105 Final Musicianship Capstone. HARD STOP after Level 105.